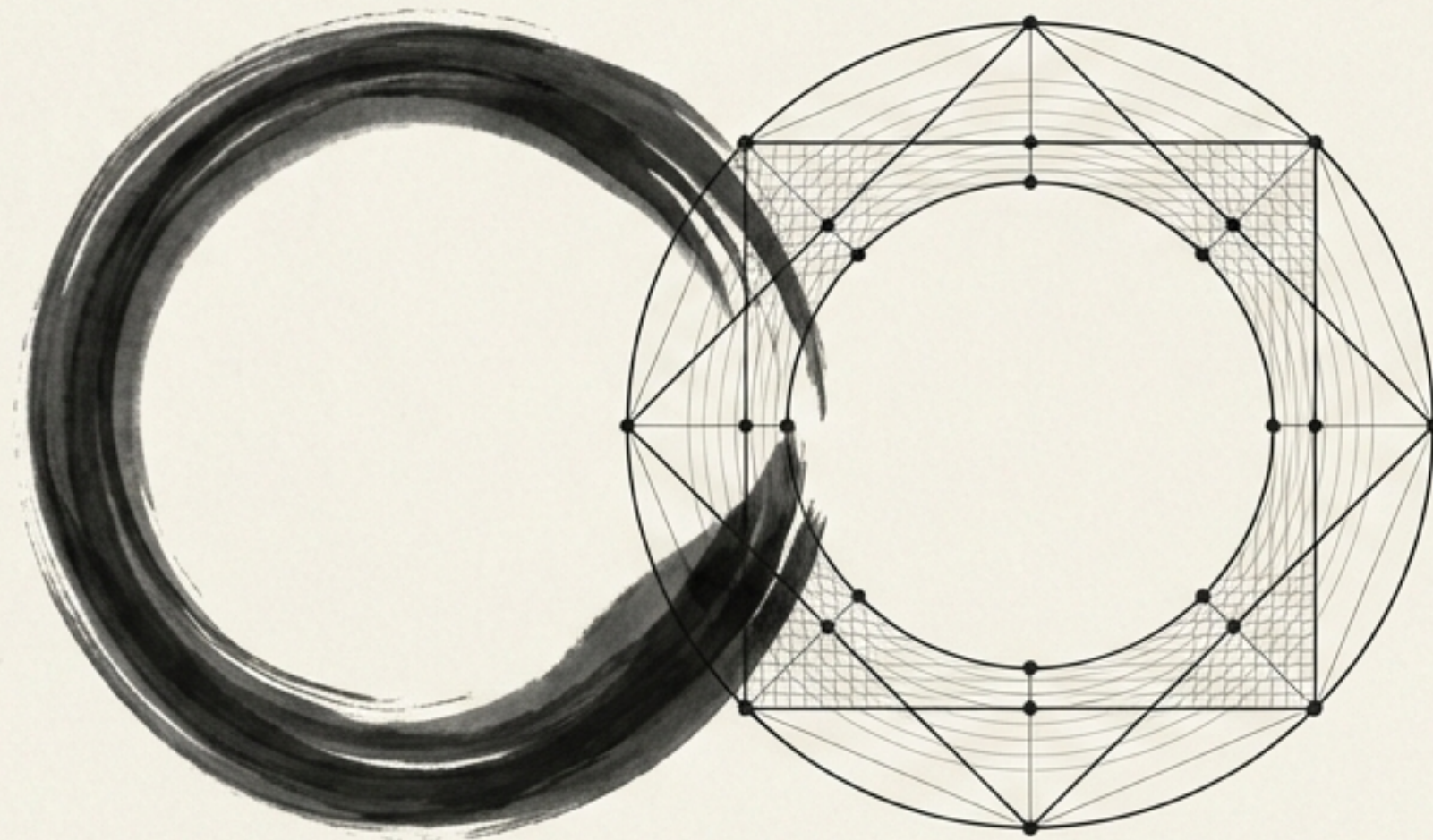


# I AND THOU

AN EXPLORATION OF THE PRIMARY WORDS BASED ON THE WORK OF MARTIN BUBER



To man the world is twofold, in accordance with his twofold attitude.



# I

## The Twofold Attitude

The world is not a single reality waiting to be observed. It changes depending on the primary word the human being speaks.

*“The primary words are not isolated words, but combined words. The one primary word is the combination I-Thou. The other primary word is the combination I-It.”*



## RELATION

*I-Thou*

The 'I' of presence, of meeting. The world is encountered as a living subject.

## EXPERIENCE

**I-It**

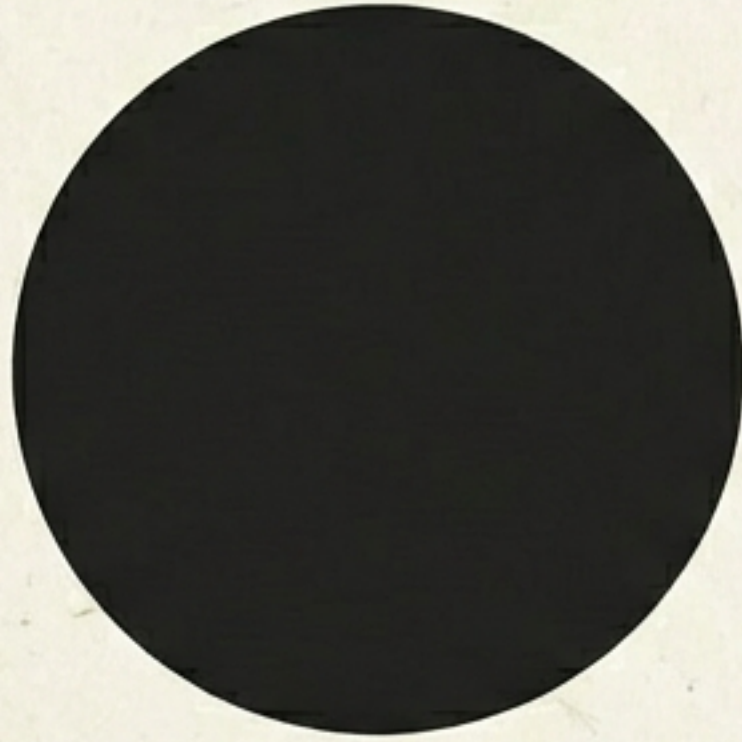
The 'I' of separation, of utilization. The world is perceived as an object (He, She, or It).

Key Insight: The I of the primary word I-Thou is a different I from that of the primary word I-It.



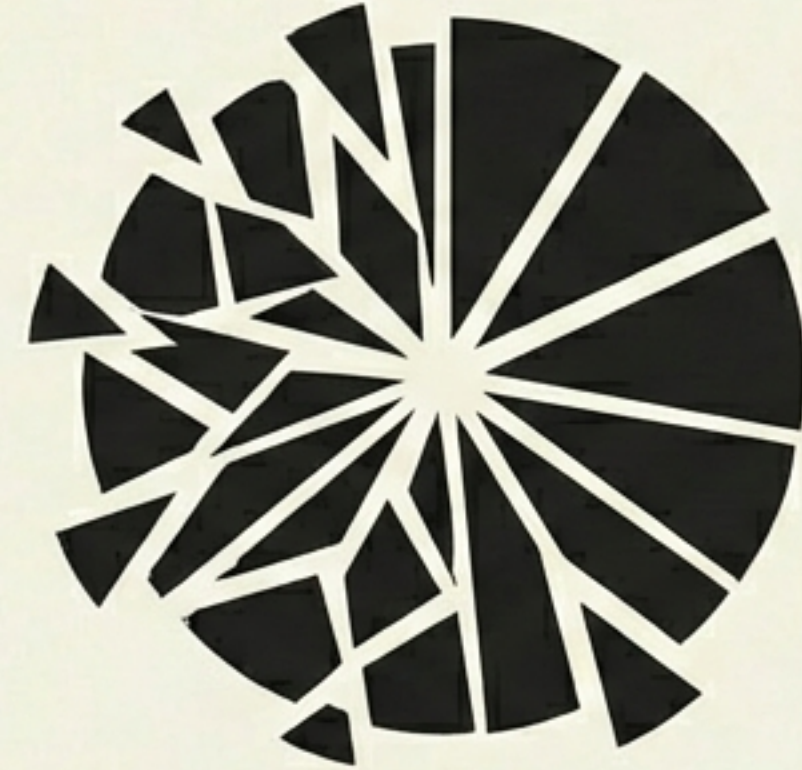
# Spoken from Being

I-Thou



Spoken with the WHOLE BEING.  
Requires total presence.

I-It

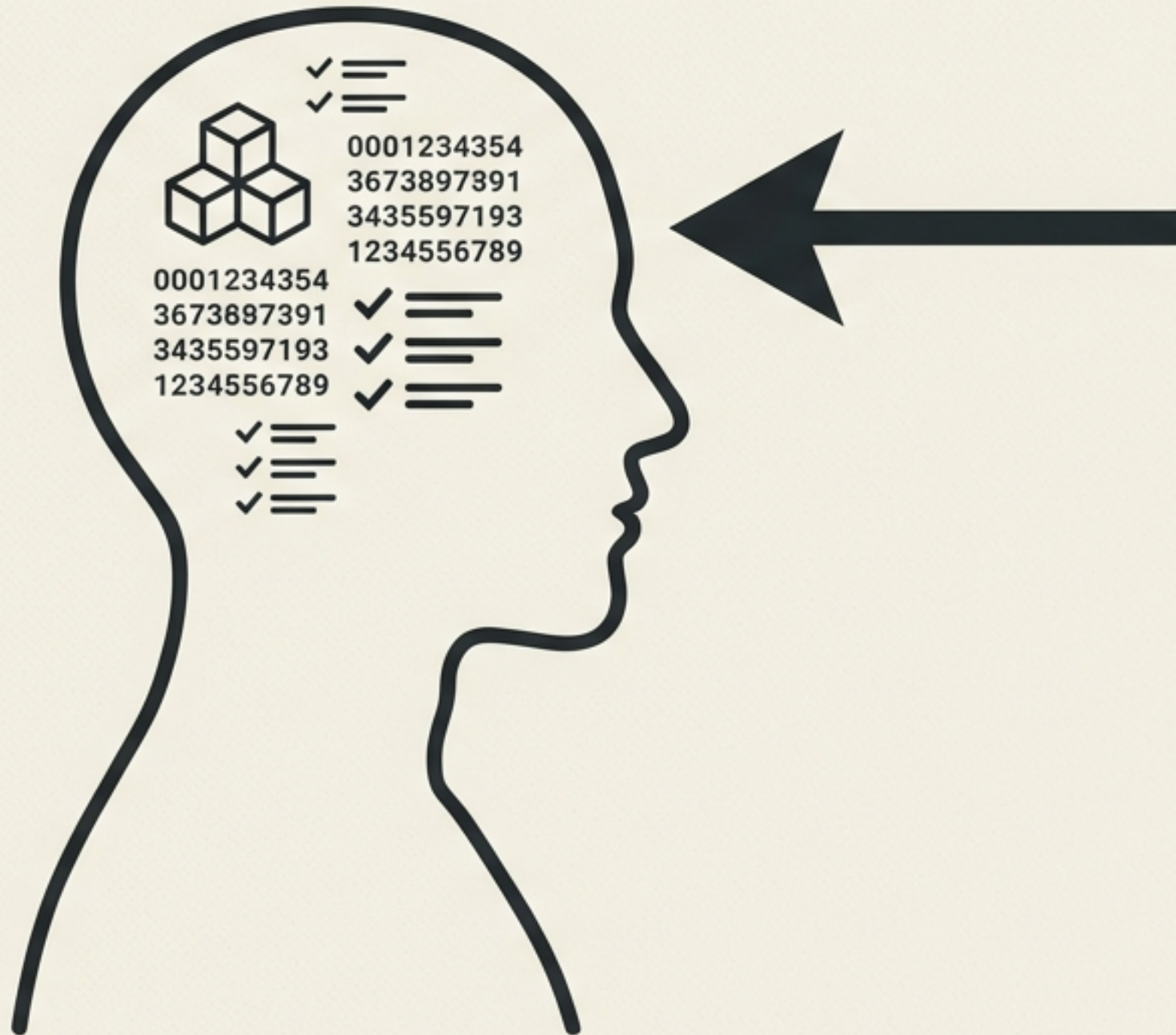


Never spoken with the whole being.  
Utilizes only a part of the self  
(intellect, senses, will).

“Primary words do not signify things, but they intimate relations...  
being spoken they bring about existence.”



# The Nature of Experience



**Core Concept:** “I experience something.”

Experience is transitive. It is an accumulation of information *about* the world.

**The Trap:** “The man who experiences has no part in the world. For it is in him and not between him and the world that the experience arises.”



# The World of Objects

The realm of It is the realm of things.

**Condition:** Every It is bounded by others; It exists only through being bounded by others.

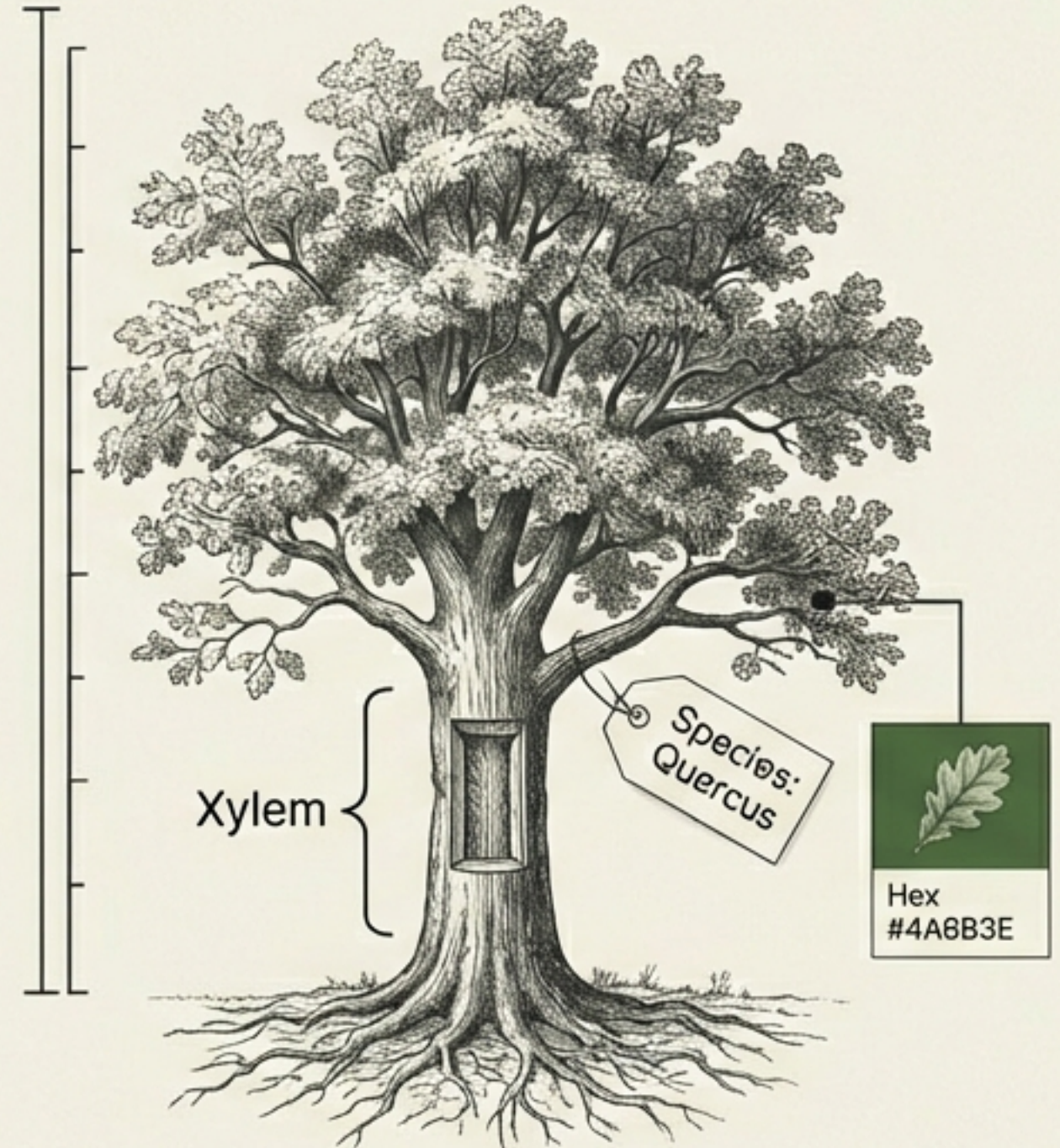
**Result:** In this world, we measure, we utilize, and we coordinate. We perceive a 'He' or 'She' or 'It' as a specific point in space and time within the net of the world.



# Case Study: The Tree (Mode I)

**Action:** I consider a tree.

1. **Picture:** A stiff column in a shock of light.
2. **Movement:** Flowing veins, sucking roots (biological process).
3. **Classification:** Subdued into a species and studied as a type.
4. **Number:** Dissipated into pure numerical relation.



In all this the tree remains my object, occupies space and time, and has its nature and constitution.



# The Past Tense



**Insight:** Objects do not exist in the “filled present.” They exist in the time that has been.

**Quote:** “The object is not duration, but cessation, suspension, a breaking off... The life of objects is in the past.”

**Takeaway:** When we classify and use things, we are interacting with what they *were*, not what they *are*.



All real living  
is meeting.

The shift from Experience to Relation.



# Case Study: The Tree (Mode II)

The Shift: "It can, however, also come about... that in considering the tree I become bound up in relation to it."

The Unity: The tree is no longer an It. The picture, movement, species, and number are not forgotten, but they are indivisibly united in this event.

The Encounter: It is bodied over against me. It has to do with me, as I with it.



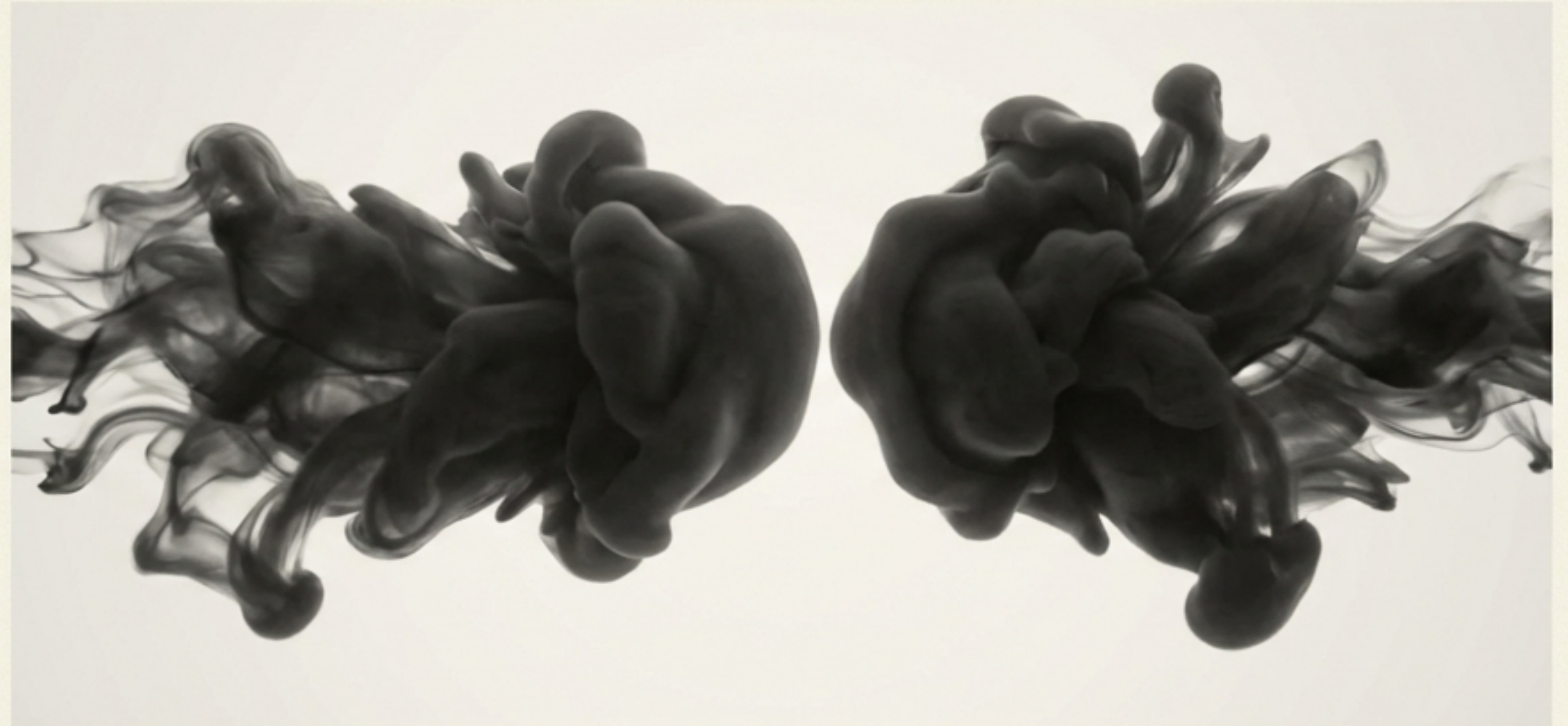


# Directness

**Definition:** The relation to the Thou is direct.

What is **Removed:**

- No system of ideas.
- No foreknowledge.
- No aim.
- No lust.



Only when every means has collapsed does the meeting come about.



# The Filled Present

**Contrast:** The “present” of the I-It world is just a fleeting point fixing the end of a time span.

**Real Reality:** The real, filled present exists only in so far as meeting and relation exist.

“True beings are lived in the present, the life of objects is in the past.”





# Love is Responsibility

**Definition:** Love is the responsibility of an I for a Thou.

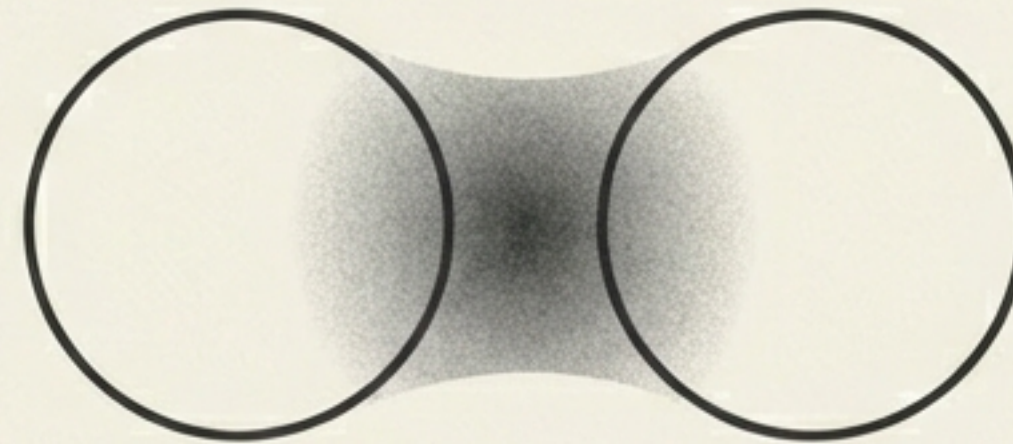
**Impact:** In the eyes of him who takes his stand in love, men are cut free from their entanglement in bustling activity and step forth in their singleness.

Feelings



Feelings happen  
IN a person.

Love



Love happens  
BETWEEN I  
and Thou.



# The Three Spheres of Relation

## Life with Nature



## Life with Men



## Life with Spiritual Beings



## Life with Nature

Pre-speech. The relation sways in gloom.

## Life with Men

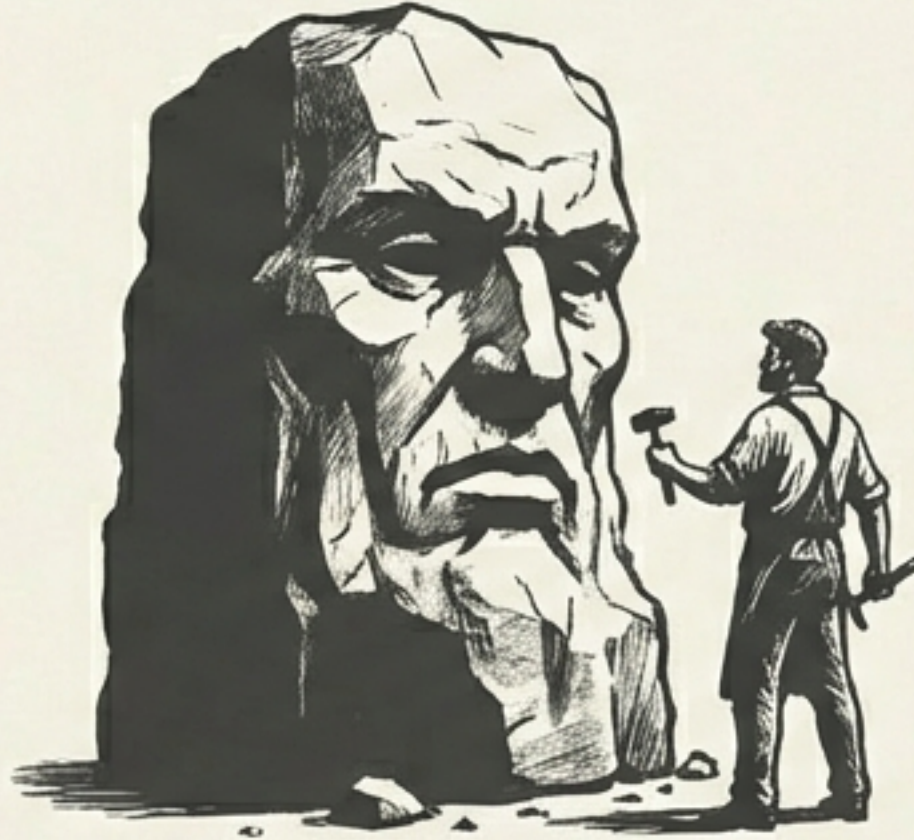
Speech-based. We can give and accept the Thou.

## Life with Spiritual Beings

Creating form. The relation is clouded but discloses itself.



# The Artist's Sacrifice



**The Encounter:** A man is faced by a form which desires to be made through him into a work.

**The Command:** 'The work does not suffer me, as do the tree and the man, to turn aside and relax in the world of It; but it commands.'

**The Risk:** To produce is to sacrifice endless possibility on the altar of the form. The primary word must be spoken with the whole being.



# The Exalted Melancholy



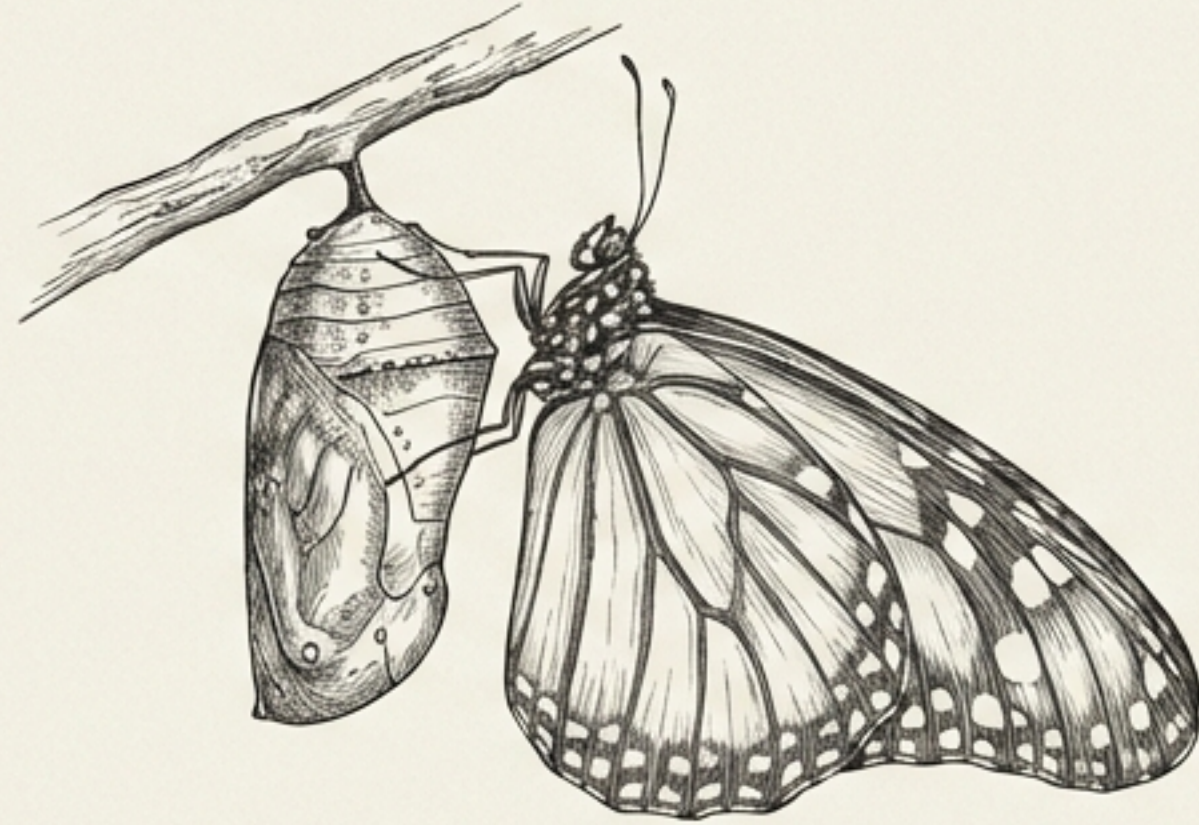
**The Fate:** 'Every Thou in our world must become an It.'

**The Process:** As soon as the relation has been permeated with a means (described, analyzed, organized), the Thou becomes an object among objects.

**Example:** Even in love, the person who was just 'single and unconditioned' becomes again a 'He' or 'She'—a sum of qualities.



# The Cycle of Being



The It is the eternal chrysalis, the Thou the eternal butterfly.

Meaning:

I-It: The necessary structure, the hardened shell, the objectified world.

I-Thou: The fleeting, living moment of reality that emerges from it.



# In the Beginning is Relation



**Anthropology:** Primitive man does not see 'objects'. He experiences relational encounters (Mana, Orenda).

**Example:** The moon is not a ball of light (It); it is a 'Thou' that seizes him with pain or pleasure.

**Key Point:** The 'I-Thou' relation precedes the 'I-It' separation.



# The Child's Reach



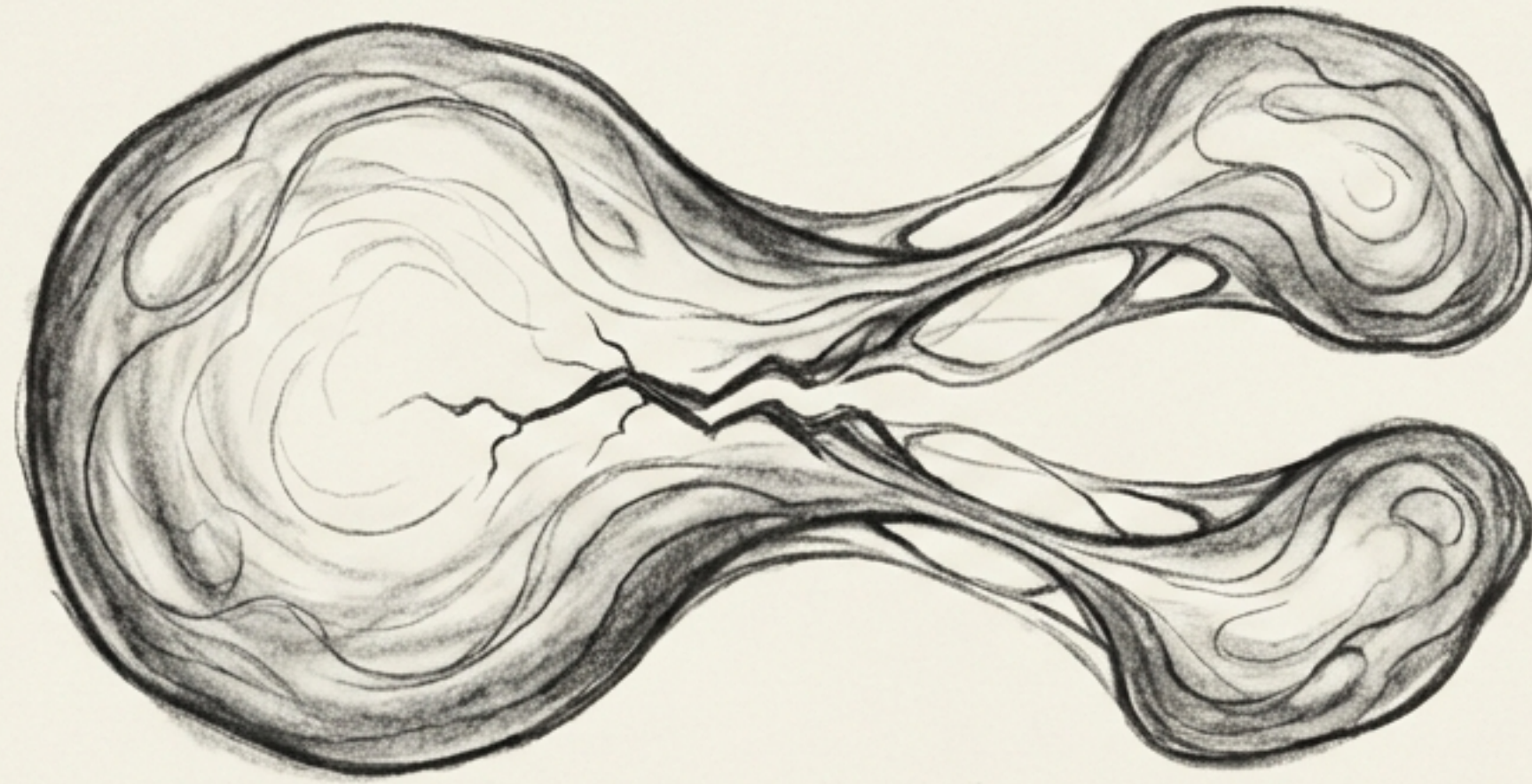
**Origin:** The child rests in the womb of the great mother—the undivided primal world.

**Action:** Before a child perceives an object, they reach out. “Hands sketch delicately and dimly in the empty air... seeking to meet something indefinite.”

**Insight:** The instinct to say ‘Thou’ (to relate) comes *before* the ability to know ‘It’ (to identify things).



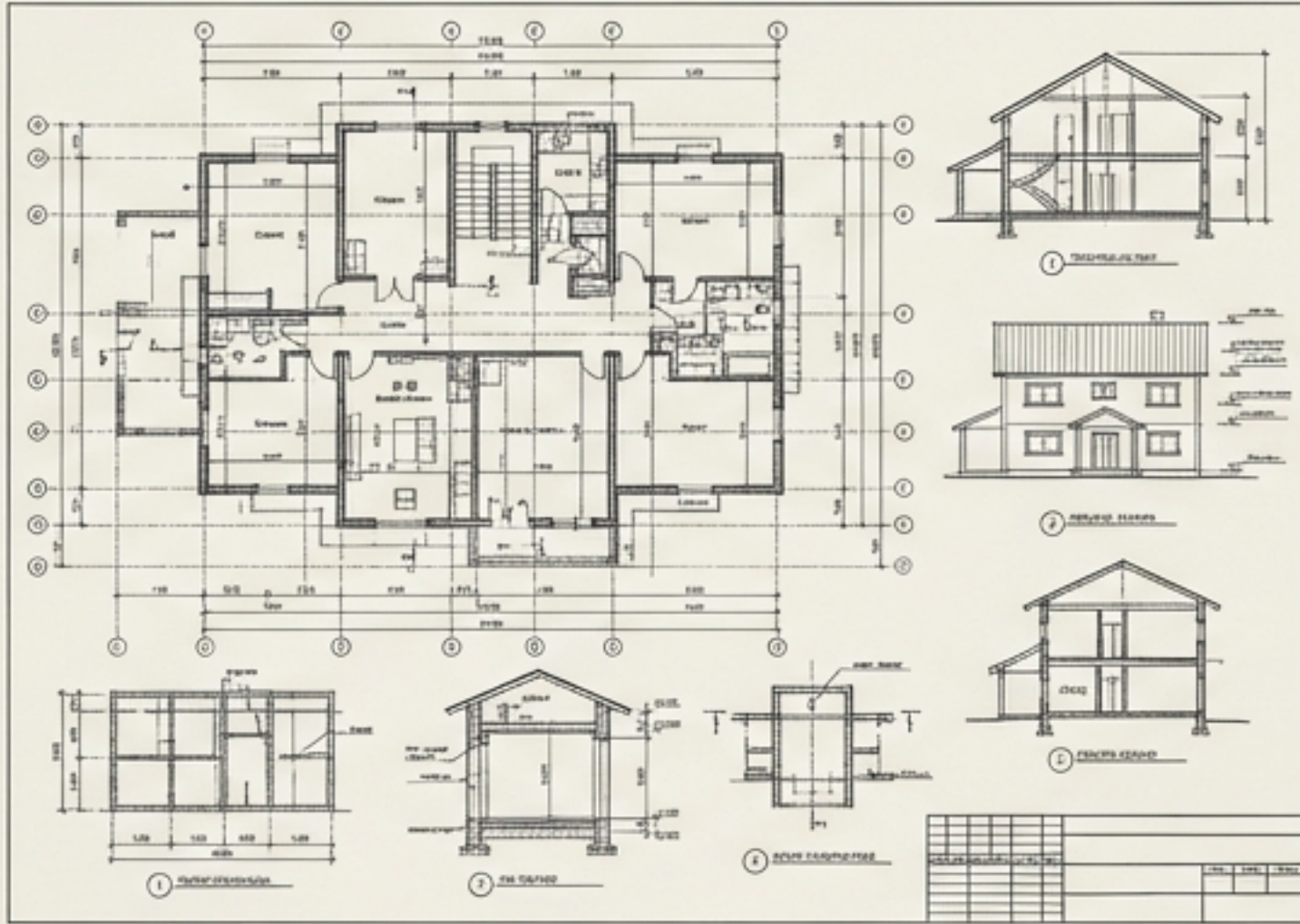
# The Birth of the Ego



- **Process:** The consciousness of the "I" is not the starting point. The "I" emerges only after the primal "I-Thou" connection is split asunder.
- **Result:** Only when the child separates themselves from the world can they speak the primary word "I-It."
- **Conclusion:** Separation is a learned achievement; relation is our native state.

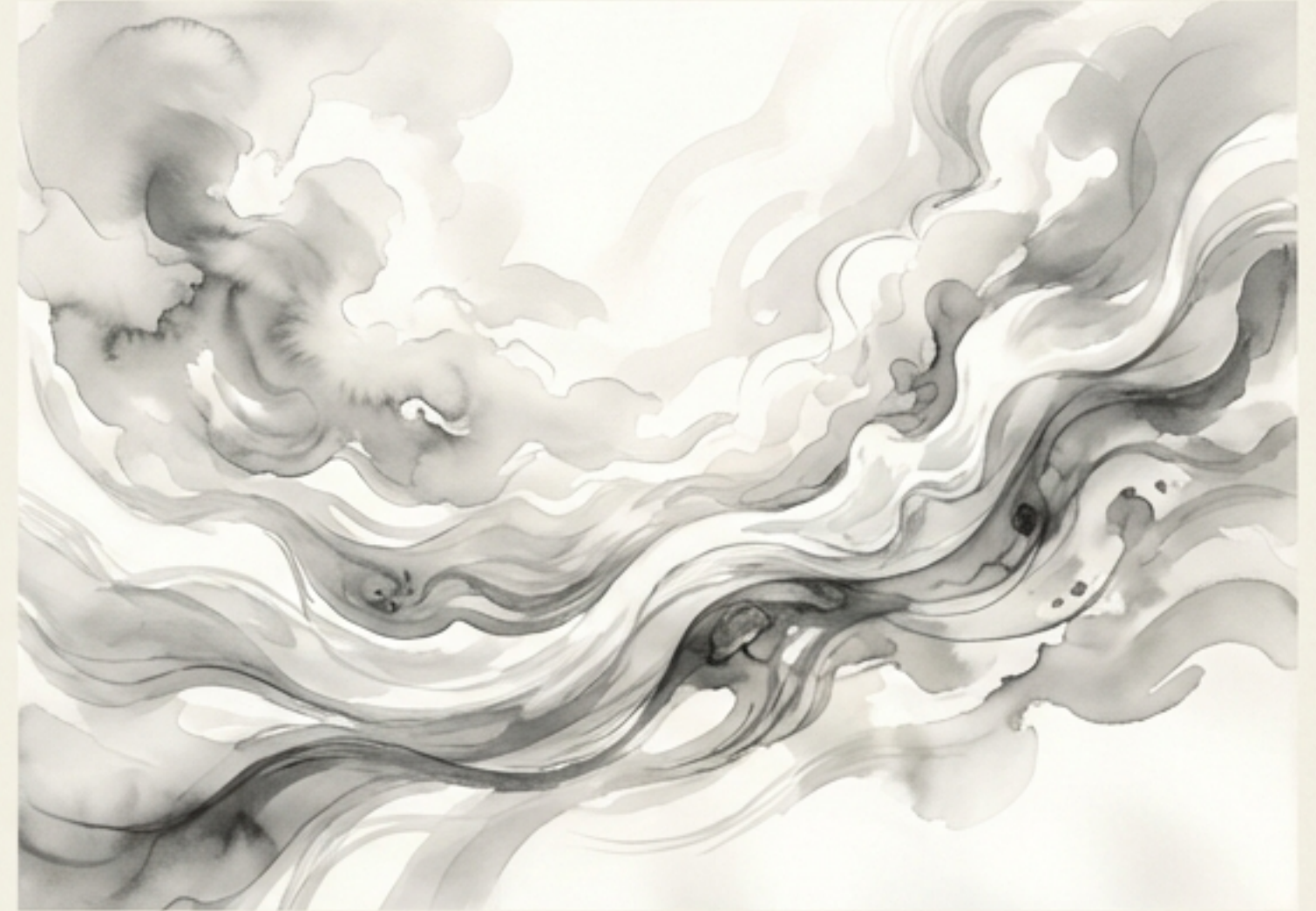


# “The Choice” in Playfair Display



The World of It.

**The Necessity:** Man cannot live without “It”.  
We must measure, build, and survive.



The World of Thou.

**The Warning:** “But he who lives with It  
alone is not a man.”

**Final Thought:** The “I” of the primary word I-It has no present,  
only the past. To live in the present is to risk the meeting.